

RHYTHMIC LICKS!

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #144

It's easy to get way too wrapped up into the hip licks and extended harmonies that we find in jazz. It's great stuff, but #9's and tritone substitutes are not the only thing for us to spend time on. In fact, it can be argued that jazz is much more about rhythm, dance and movement than it is about harmonic sophistication.

The rhythms that a soloist, singer or comping musician (guitar, piano, drums, etc) play affect the entire band, for the positive and for the negative. Having an arsenal of great "rhythm licks" will serve us well. As with melodic licks and harmonic devices, these rhythmic licks each have a flavor, a vibe and a sense of place. It's time to get some of these into your ears and under your fingers.

Here, we'll look at two great rhythms that each have a very different effect. #1 (below) is a rhythm and lick that Harry "Sweets" Edison used to love to play. It had a very swinging, very driving quarter note feel to it, and it would definitely help to propel that band forward. Item #2 (below) is more of an "anti-swinging" idea, something that is based on square 16th notes with a short articulation. It is quirky sounding, tongue in cheek, and is the sort of rhythm that Thad Jones used to love to compose into some of his great big band arrangements.

The image displays two musical licks, #1 and #2, in 4/4 time. Lick #1 is a four-measure phrase starting with a C7 chord, followed by F7, C7, and C7. It features a driving quarter-note feel with accents on the first and third notes of each measure. Lick #2 is an eight-measure phrase starting with F7, followed by F7, C7, B7, Bb7, and A7. It features a quirky, anti-swinging feel with square 16th notes and short articulation. The notation includes treble clefs, 4/4 time signatures, and various chords and notes with accents.